



Media Information

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Crowd-Pleasers in Their Second Generation: 50 Years of Opel Ascona B and Manta B

- Summer 1975: Ascona B and Manta B continue the success of the first vehicle generation
- Sporty, comfortable, efficient: Second model generation builds on typical Opel virtues
- Built for rally and motorsport fans: Manta GT/E, Ascona 400 and Manta 400
- Dynamic, emotional, resource-conscious: Current Opel compact-class bestseller as all-electric Astra Electric and powerful Astra GSe plug-in hybrid

Combined values for Opel Astra Electric according to WLTP¹: energy consumption 15.6 kWh/100 km, CO₂ emissions 0 g/km; CO₂ label: A.

Combined values for Opel Astra GSe according to WLTP¹: Weighted energy consumption weighted 17.7 kWh electricity/100 km plus 1.3 l petrol/100 km; CO₂ emissions 30 g/km; CO₂ label B. Fuel consumption when battery empty 6.2 l/100 km; CO₂ label E.

Rüsselsheim. Sporty design, dynamic driving performance with maximum efficiency, and at the same time an ideal family car with plenty of interior space – today, anyone looking for these qualities in a car usually thinks of the [Opel Astra](#). The compact-class bestseller from Rüsselsheim presents an emotional design, space for up to five people including luggage and a choice of powertrains unmatched by no other Opel model, including the all-electric, locally emissions-free [Astra Electric](#) as well as the highly dynamic, also electrified top-of-the-range [Astra GSe](#) model with 165 kW (225 hp) system output and 360 Newton metres of maximum torque.

But **50 years ago**, customers were already finding these virtues at Opel, with a focus on the essentials, pleasant travelling comfort and maximum efficiency. In fact, they were spoilt for choice: should it be an **Opel Ascona** or instead an **Opel Manta**? The second generation of both models were launched in the summer of 1975; the Ascona B and

¹ A vehicle's values not only depend on the vehicle's efficient use of fuel, but are also influenced by driving behaviour and other non-technical factors.



Manta B celebrated their premieres at the IAA in Frankfurt – sharing the same technical basis but with different characteristics aimed at different customer groups. The special sports versions of these two models are even more impressive and have achieved international success. The Ascona B and Manta B prove that sometimes sequels can be even better than the originals!

Generational change: Ascona and Manta A are followed by new editions in 1975

The first generation laid the foundation for the success of both Opel models. Launched in 1970 as Opel's 'new class', the Ascona A closed the gap between the Kadett and Rekord. In the same year, the new Opel Manta A also made its debut and soon became – like its characteristic ray emblem – a cult favourite. Both models, with their well-balanced design, quickly won the hearts of hundreds of thousands of buyers.

In 1975, the second generation of the successful models arrived. The new **Ascona B** was visibly more spacious than its predecessor. The body was around 20 centimetres longer and 4 centimetres wider than before; the wheelbase also grew by almost 9 centimetres. All this benefited passenger comfort, offering greater legroom and shoulder space, along with comfortable full-foam seats featuring excellent damping properties and backrests with reinforced side support. The newly developed front chassis also improved drive and travelling comfort. The extended wheelbase, wider tracks front and rear, and longer spring travel of the last rear-wheel drive Ascona ensured balanced, safe handling.

Opel's engineers and designers knew how to focus on the essentials, even back then. The smoother and more functional design language of the second Ascona generation demonstrates this well. Take efficiency: despite the increased frontal area, air resistance and thus fuel consumption were reduced; the same applied to wind noise – all of this thanks to aerodynamic refinement. A lower beltline and around 20 per cent larger glass surfaces had a positive effect both on the spacious feeling and on all-round visibility thus enhancing safety.

Sharing the same technical basis as the Ascona B, but designed as a sporty coupé, the **Manta B** celebrated its premiere at the IAA in 1975. Unusual for a vehicle in its class at the time, it combined exemplary driving performance and handling characteristics with



excellent economy and space for up to five people. The second-generation Manta was characterised by its slim, elongated silhouette with a low bonnet, generous glazing and large rectangular headlights. An integral roll bar was also standard, enhancing passive safety.

Built for the track: Opel Manta GT/E, Ascona 400 and Manta 400

Much enthusiasm for the Ascona B and Manta B stemmed from their numerous – and also very sporty – models and variants. The ‘small saloon’ **Manta Berlinetta**, for example, featured elegant velour upholstery, sports rims and a sports steering wheel, exuding luxurious sportiness. In 1975 Opel introduced the **Manta GT/E** as a ‘collector’s item with sporty dynamics and racy elegance’. It lived up to its promise: the matt black bonnet, the – even then – largely chrome-free trim, and in the interior, the metal-spoked sports steering wheel and full set of instruments from rev counter to voltmeter and oil pressure gauge, convinced enthusiasts, as did the firmer suspension and more direct steering. Car testers at the time noted that the GT/E, with its 77 kW (105 hp) and top speed of up to 185 km/h, matched or even outperformed competitor models with nominally higher outputs.

However, one special number in connection with the Ascona B and Manta B still makes the hearts of motorsport enthusiasts and rally fans beat faster: 400! As early as the 1970s, the Ascona achieved numerous successes in international rallying. In 1974, Walter Röhrl and Jochen Berger won the [European Rally Championship](#) in an Ascona A; this was followed by six national rally championships. But the highlight for Opel came with the new sporty top version **Ascona 400** introduced in 1979: With a 2.4-litre DOHC engine and 106 kW (144 hp) power, disc brakes rear and five-speed gearbox, it formed the basis for the 191 kW (260 hp) strong rally car with which [Röhrl finally won the world championship title in 1982](#). The Opel Ascona 400 Group 4 thus became the last rear-wheel drive to win the rally word title.

The ‘400’ then transferred to the Opel Manta. In 1981 Opel presented the **Manta 400** at the Geneva Motor Show and at the IAA in Frankfurt/Main as the successor to the Ascona 400. While the street version of the 2.4-litre 16V engine still offered 106 kW (144 hp), the optimised engine (Phase III) of the competition vehicle, which was intended for sports use only, produced around 206 kW (280 hp) – a pure power car! In 1983 Erwin Weber and



Gunter Wanger secured the German Rally Championship in a Manta 400; in France, Guy Fréquelin won the championship title in the same year.

The Manta B remained in production in various versions until 1988, making it Opel's longest-produced model generation at 13 years. Furthermore, it boasted an exemplary low drag coefficient of c_w 0.352, undercutting even some sports cars of its day. Its potential 'successor' was already waiting in the wings at the end of the 1980s: in 1989 Opel presented the Calibra. This timelessly beautiful two-door coupé from Rüsselsheim quickly became the most successful sports coupé of the 1990s. With a drag coefficient of just 0.26, it was considered the world's most streamlined series car for ten years, earning it the name 'aerodynamics world champion'.

About Opel

Opel is one of the largest European car manufacturers and started building automobiles in Germany in 1899. Opel is part of Stellantis NV and is the first German brand to already offer all models with a fully electric drive based on its multi-energy platforms. The company thus gives its customers the freedom to decide for themselves how they want to travel and ensures that the future mobility demands of customers are met. Opel and its British sister brand Vauxhall stand for affordable mobility and are represented in more than 60 countries.

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